



Humanities Survey

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · ONE SEMESTER ·
½ CREDIT · ELECTIVE

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. This page is drawn from the official course descriptions rather than a built Optima course, so the specific works, cultures, and activities scholars study will be set by the teacher and may vary between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Humanities Survey introduces scholars to the major creative expressions across civilizations — art, literature, architecture, music, philosophy, and religion — that reveal how humans understand themselves and their world. Through studying these interconnected forms of expression, scholars encounter the ideas, beliefs, and questions that have shaped civilizations and continue to shape our own. They examine how artists, writers, philosophers, and religious thinkers from different cultures address enduring human concerns: meaning, justice, beauty, mortality, and community. In a VR- and AI-enhanced learning environment, scholars encounter artworks, texts, and cultural artifacts from across time and cultures. The course develops both knowledge of human cultural achievement and the ability to see how different forms of expression illuminate one another.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Reading the Arts (foundation)

How to look at, listen to, and read works of art, architecture, music, theatre, and literature — and the vocabulary to discuss them.

3 Enduring Human Questions (strand)

How artists, writers, philosophers, and religious thinkers confront meaning, justice, beauty, mortality, and community.

5 Heritage and Today (strand)

How cultural heritage shapes contemporary society, and how the trends of the past explain the present.

2 Culture and Context (strand)

How historical events, social context, and belief shape the forms, techniques, and purposes of works in the arts.

4 The Arts Across Civilizations (strand)

Relating works to the cultures and periods that produced them, and comparing how different traditions answer the same questions.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Close study of artworks, texts, and cultural artifacts, most days, with text-based discussion.
- Immersive encounters with works across time and cultures on Optima's VR campus.
- Evidence-based writing that connects forms of expression and the questions they address.
- Research and presentation tasks that make cross-cultural connections.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday, for one semester

- Study, discussion, and writing fill most of the scheduled time.
- Research and project weeks may run longer.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- A notebook for observations, vocabulary, and research notes.
- Access to Optima's VR campus for immersive encounters with art and culture.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, when offered live; for 2026–27 Humanities Survey is listed as an On-Demand course.